

Waiting in the wings
An Air India plane among other aircraft at Mumbai airport, Oct. 2021

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MILESTONES

1947
India has 74 DC-3 Dakotas, 12 Vikings, 3 DC-4s and various smaller craft, which **largely flew VIPs**

Tata's Air India starts international services with a weekly flight from Bombay to London via Cairo and Geneva

1953
Airways industry is nationalised. Indian Airlines is set up. Tata-owned international routes are taken over to form Air India

1960
Air India begins operating its first Boeing 707-437. It also marks the year in which the USA is first connected to India by an Indian airliner

1990
India decides to **end Air India's monopoly** in the domestic sector. East West Airlines becomes the first national level private airline to operate in the country

1995
Laws are amended to make Director General of Civil Aviation regulator; **private players allowed.** 10 per cent of air traffic come from the private sector

2003
Air Deccan, **India's first-ever national budget airline** is started. In this decade, a series of policy changes are made to allow low-cost carriers to operate

2000
The first attempt made to privatise Air India fails

1997
A group of army aviation professionals sets up **Deccan Aviation.** It becomes India's largest privately owned helicopter charter company

2007
Air India and Indian Airlines merge and spiral into a debt trap. $96 million of combined debt becomes $900 million in the next two years

2010
India opens a world-class **integrated air terminal (T3)** at Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi

2018
Pakyong airport in Sikkim becomes the **100th operational airport** in the country

2022
Post-pandemic, the air traffic is coming back with 100 million people taking domestic flights and airlines operating at around 80 per cent capacity

2021
Air India along with Air India Express **sold to Tata Sons** for Rs 18,000 crore

2020
Vistara begins flying to London taking narrow carriers from India on long haul flights

back to Tata Sons. In seven decades, the country's skies have seen a massive change, though India might be slow in adding to air infrastructure like airports, upgrading the equipment and aeroplanes. Along with inefficiency in decision-making, the poor health of airlines and poor policies are to be blamed. In 1995, when India started opening up its skies to private players again, investments started flowing in. So did failures. Two big airlines—Kingfisher and Jet Airways—failed, and SpiceJet struggled financially and had to change many hands. Today, more than 10 private players provide passenger services. And players such as IndiGo, SpiceJet, Go Air and Vistara—a joint venture between Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines—are already flying to foreign shores. In fact, Vistara went ahead and is taking narrow-body aircraft on long-haul flights to London. SpiceJet is following suit, by opening up more markets for the Indian players.

India might be slower than its global peers to take off, but make no mistake, it is catching up. All it needs to focus on is in maintaining quality. ■